

Lenovo ThinkCentre A61e

Green PC

Go Green! Seems to be the mantra these days and every manufacturer is doling out power efficient products. Lenovo's A61e is based on AMD's DTX form factor—the first of its kind, consisting of their power optimised processor, chipset and graphics.

The A series of desktops from Lenovo are oriented towards business and hence don't expect this PC to churn out big numbers—it isn't meant too. The A61e is designed to consume less space—an important aspect for most businesses. We found the dimensions very compact for a full fledged PC—great for Media centre PCs. Despite the diminutive form factor the PC doesn't get hot—thanks to good ventilation and low power components.

The configuration offers a decent balance between

performance and power consumption. AMD's Athlon 64 X2 BE-2350 (power optimised) processor along with ATI's X1200 onboard graphics power the PC's critical systems. The motherboard is custom built, and hence we could not trace its manufacturer. Other goodies include 1 GB of memory, 160 GB hard drive, DVD writer and Gigabit Ethernet. The PC doesn't run directly off the mains, rather it requires the provided power adapter similar to a laptop. The tight fit of components means, upgradeability is limited. However, the system admin will appreciate the tool-case, which opens by sliding a single latch.

Along with the A61e, Lenovo has bundled the familiar black keyboard and optical mouse. The A61e can be ordered without any display. However, our test unit



had their 20-inch LCD monitor. During our tests, the LCD fared well and delivered good tonal accuracy. The LCD is fit for any office related work, i.e. Word processing, spreadsheets, browsing etc.

When we upgraded the memory to 2GB the PC shifted its gear and delivered reasonable results. With all the eye candy on, Vista requires at least 2 GB for other applications to work. With Windows XP, we had no problem with the

stock configuration. The performance was satisfying. We tried Ubuntu 7.10. The PC did boot, but with minor glitches such as wrong screen resolution, no sound, etc., which needed some fixing.

The A61e without the monitor is sweetly priced at Rs 15,800.

Specifications

AMD Athlon 64X2, 1 GB DDRII, 160 GB HDD, DVD-RW, X1200 onboard graphics, Keyboard, optical mouse, Gigabit Ethernet and PC DOS.

Contact: Lenovo India Pvt. Ltd
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E-mail: buy@in.lenovo.com
Web site: www.lenovo.com/in
Price: Rs 15,800

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

CoolerMaster CM690

Keep Your Cool

CoolerMaster or CM as it's commonly referred to, enjoys the patronage of enthusiasts thanks largely to their attractive STACKER and COSMOS cabinets, which fall in the upper echelon of the desktop cabinets. The CM690, on the other hand promises the performance and designer looks of the higher end at a reasonable price.

A thin chrome strips runs across the entire length of the mess and it contrasts nicely with the black mesh. The chunky rubber feet with slanting cuts give the case a sporty stance.

The front panel connectors have been moved to the top and consist of two USBs, one Firewire and one eSATA port. Thumb screws mean opening the case requires no tools. The side panel



comes out with minimum effort. Except for the motherboard, all other components can be installed without screws.

Near the front, there are five 5.25-inch bays and another five 3.5-inch bays for connecting optical drives and hard drives, respectively. A large 120-

mm fan ensures the hard drives are kept cool. The cabling can be routed within the case using the sturdy clamps provided inside. The case comes with three 120-mm fans installed and additional 3 fans can be installed to cool the components.

Everything from the side panels and power supply housing, to the HDD trays and the fan mounts have silent, (read rubber), treatment to keep the dBs down. There are two rubber lined holes for passing liquid cooling pipes too. The side panel has a stylish cut and displays your wares in their full glory.

The CM690 performs well and handles even a Core

2 Duo X6800 and GeForce 8800GTX with a RAID 0 hard drive array without breaking a sweat. This along with three 120-mm fans—one at the rear (exhaust), one in the front (intake) and another exhaust on the side panel.

The CM690 retails for some 4,000 odd bucks and for that price it's a steal. In case you are planning to build a gaming PC, then the CM690 should be on your must have list. Though a tad expensive than the normal beige boxes, the CM690 makes up for it in every conceivable way.

Specifications

Form factor—Mid Tower, 3.5-inch bays—5, 5.25-inch bays—5, No of fans—3x120 mm, side panel cut (acrylic) tool less design.

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RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆